

An Adventure on the Train

We graduated from school in 1976, but those of us who had gone to Tashkent to study kept meeting up regularly until we finished our degrees. Sometimes we would travel back to Bukhara together. I want to tell you about one of the things that happened on one of those journeys.

It was 1977. If I remember correctly, it was around the November holiday. If I get any details wrong, I ask those who were there to correct me. Yodgorova Mayram, Roziya, and I had decided to come home for the holiday break. The girls probably figured it would be better to have at least one young man along. As for me, I was happy to travel with my classmates — good company, never a dull moment.

We set off. The Tashkent–Bukhara train, a third-class open-berth carriage, the journey smooth, our spirits high. Evening came, the girls fell asleep, and so did I. I woke up early in the morning — most passengers were still asleep. The train stopped at a station. The thought crossed my mind: 'Why not step out and pick up some kefir and milk for breakfast?' — and so I got off.

Just behind the door of our carriage, I noticed a sign reading 'Buffet'. I headed that way. The station turned out to be called 'Zirabuloq'. I went inside. Dairy products, bread, rolls — everything was there. I asked the woman behind the counter for a bottle of sour cream and a loaf of bread. She put everything into a paper bag. I had three rubles — I handed them over. 'I'll bring your change in a moment,' she said and disappeared into the back room. After a while she came back and pressed one ruble and one or two fifteen-kopeek coins into my hand.

I picked up my things and walked out of the buffet. I looked up — the train was moving! I ran, caught up with the train, but it was the last carriage — and its door was shut. The door of the carriage in front, however, was open. I could have simply grabbed the handle of the last carriage's door and ridden that way to the next station, then quickly moved forward — but the train was still moving slowly, and I thought: 'If I sprint hard enough, I can reach that open door.'

I ran faster, but... just as I was nearly at the door, the train surged ahead of me. I was falling behind. There was nothing left but to grab the handle of the last carriage and hang on until the next stop. The rear door of the last carriage rushed up fast despite my

speed. Now it was no longer enough to simply grab it — I had to leap and catch the handle in mid-air. I jumped, gripped the handle tightly, but... the momentum slammed me into the side of the carriage and my hands were torn free. I felt a powerful blow from behind, and for a moment I lost consciousness.

When I came to, I was lying across the rails. The first rail ran beneath my knees, the second beneath my shoulder blades. Several people from the station were running toward me. A Russian voice called out: 'He's alive, he came round — lucky it was the last carriage, otherwise the poor fellow would have been in pieces... shame about the vodka, though...' He had taken the broken glass for vodka bottles.

I got up. There was just a small smear of sour cream on my shirt. Apart from the ache in my back and a slightly grazed hand, it was as if nothing had happened at all. The bread and sour cream lay scattered along the track and the embankment, mixed with broken glass. I stepped off the rails. People offered to help, but I could walk fine on my own. They asked what had happened — I told them everything.

An older Russian man said to me: 'Sonny, listen to me. If you want to get back to your travelling companions as fast as possible, don't wait here for the next train. See those taxis over there? Tell them you want to go to Ziyavuddin. They'll start at twenty-five, the ride itself is worth a tenner — but they're taxis, you know how it is. You can bargain them down to ten, they'll agree.'

I said: 'I've only got a ruble and some change,' and showed him the money.

The man said: 'When you get there — climb out of the taxi, toss whatever money you've got on the seat, and run for it. I don't think he'll catch you.'

Having learned from him what 'a twenty-five' and 'a tenner' meant, I went over to the taxis. True enough, they started at twenty-five rubles; I just barely talked them down to ten and got in. The taxi drove on, my heart thumping. In my head: 'What am I going to do? What if he catches me? What if he humiliates me in front of everyone?...' The road felt endless.

At last the station came into view, and our train was standing at the platform. 'Here we are, nearly arrived,' said the driver. I immediately said: 'Stop right here!' The moment the taxi braked I flung open the door and sprinted off across the road. A tall

wooden fence appeared out of nowhere — and I still don't know how I got over it. I ran until I was exhausted, then stopped and caught my breath.

I looked down — my left hand was clenched in a fist. I opened it: one ruble and some coins... I had forgotten to throw the money in the taxi. I crept back to Ziyavuddin station, nervous and looking over my shoulder. The taxi that had brought me was already gone — but so was the train.

I stood there wondering what to do next, and then in the distance, from the direction of Zirabuloq where I had come from, a train appeared. When it pulled in and stopped, I climbed into the nearest carriage without a second thought. It was a third-class carriage with free berths — I sat down in the first empty one. A military officer was sitting opposite me.

Before long the carriage attendant came over and asked for my ticket. I gave him a brief account of what had happened (leaving out the part about the taxi) and handed over all the money I had (one ruble and the coins). The attendant said: 'God was watching over you — a good thing it was the last carriage. Take your money back — it won't even cover the bus from Navoi to Bukhara. Just explain it to the driver, he'll understand' — and gave my money back.

The train turned out to be the Tashkent–Uchkuduk service, passing through Navoi. The officer sitting opposite me had three stars on his epaulettes, though I hadn't paid attention to whether they were large or small, or how many stripes there were. He seemed too young to be a colonel. In the seventies it was rare to meet a colonel of thirty-five or forty. So I believe he was a senior lieutenant.

Curious about my appearance, my condition, and my conversation with the attendant, he turned to the attendant and asked: 'What happened?' The attendant gave him a short account of my story.

The lieutenant asked: 'Where are you headed, brother?' From his speech I could tell he was Ukrainian.

My Russian wasn't fluent, but I could get my meaning across: 'Bukhara.'

Lieutenant: 'Will a ruble get you home?'

Me: 'Yes, I'll talk to the driver, I think he'll understand.'

The lieutenant was quiet for a moment, then took out his wallet, pulled out a banknote, and held it out to me. From the colour I could see it was ten rubles.

Me: 'No, thanks, I'll manage without it — thank you!'

Lieutenant: 'Listen, life is unpredictable. Only God knows what tomorrow will bring. Time passes — and maybe one day you'll find yourself in the same situation I'm in right now, and someone will be in your place. When that happens, pass these on to them' — and he pressed the note into my hand.

After those words I couldn't say no. I took the money and thanked him. We soon arrived at Navoi. I said goodbye to the officer and the attendant and got off the train. A thought passed through my mind: 'What wonderful people there are in this world...'

I quickly made my way to the Navoi bus station and bought a ticket to Bukhara. I boarded the bus and arrived safely at the Bukhara bus terminal. I walked into the waiting hall — and there in a corner sat my travelling companions, Roziya and Mayram. I rushed over to them, and I could see — their faces were drained of colour. When they saw me, both of them stood up and... looked at me in a way that said everything.

We boarded the 'Sovkhoz-8' bus to Khargush. The whole way we rode in silence — each of us got off at our own house. I thought to myself: they probably won't want to travel with an idiot like me again. Later I found out they had been through a great deal themselves: they had told the attendant their companion had vanished — he had reported it to the train commander, announcements had been made through the carriages, enquiries sent to the stations... They were told the worst might have happened. Just imagine — what those two young girls must have gone through...

They still didn't know what this fool was going to get up to in Oqtosh — but that's a story for another time, still to come...

In all my years since, I never found myself in the situation the lieutenant had described. And to this day, I still owe him ten rubles.